(PMO) and not in the foreign ministry. Modi has risen to the office of prime minister from heading the state government in Gujarat, without earlier serving in the Union cabinet. He is an outsider to Delhi's bureaucracy and traditional power brokers in the mould of Rajiv Gandhi and Vajpayee. Reflecting his position as the key, perhaps only, decision maker, Modi has handpicked both his ministerial colleagues as well as the key civil servants working under him.

His right hand man from Gujarat, Amit Shah, was chosen to head the BJP as party president. Senior party leaders above a certain age were forced into retirement while other potential contenders to power within BJP were incorporated into the cabinet. Emulating Rajiv, Modi changed his foreign secretary in order to nominate a candidate, career diplomat Subrahmanyam Jaishankar, whom he identified as sharing his own world view. Like Vajpayee, he depends on his national security adviser, former intelligence officer Ajit Kumar Doval, for advice on both internal and external security.

Modi is in charge of his foreign policy and seems to understand the intrinsic link between economic growth and projection of power abroad. Unlike Nehru, he does not seek stature for India solely through speeches in international forums though he is not averse to that variety of international attention. He actively pursues economic partnerships and investment and wants international and Indian business to collaborate in expanding manufacturing in India. His first act of foreign policy took place even before he was sworn in as prime minister. In May 2014, he invited all South Asian heads of government to his inauguration.

South Asia, India's immediate periphery, will perhaps remain critical to every Indian prime minister and every Indian administration. In his first two years in office, Modi emphasized his regional focus by travelling to a number of India's immediate neighbours including Afghanistan, Bhutan, Nepal, Mauritius, Myanmar, Sri Lanka and Bangladesh. During his visit to Dhaka, India and Bangladesh signed a land border agreement which was